cartilage of the ear to put huge, distinctive earrings through them. Many naked ascetics, disciples of the Balnath, came out of their caves to receive the respectful salutations of the camp followers. They were a sect of sun-worshippers, according to Monserrate, and saluted the rising sun with ‘the concerted sound of flutes and conches’. They lived a frugal life, eating ‘only cooked lentils and ghi’. They had a reputation for communicating with the spirit world and practising magic, exorcism, witchcraft, and some primitive medicine. The Gorakhnath sect had rejected traditional religious practices and, like the Bhakts of Kabir, sought an identity that could ‘somehow be both Hindu and Muslim and neither, all at the same time’. One of their sayings was ‘the Hindu calls on Ram, the Muslim on Khuda, the yogi calls on the invisible one, in whom there is neither Ram nor Khuda’. Akbar walked up to the top of the hill and ‘did reverence to the place and to the prophet with bare feet and loosened hair’.

It was when the Mughal camp finally reached the river Indus, known locally as the Blue Water, that the army faltered for the first time. ‘Some were influenced by ignorance,’ grumbled Abu’l Fazl, ‘some by smallness of intellect, some by dread of a cold country…and a love for India.’ The world had changed since the time Babur had to plead with his Chaghatai clansmen to remain in hot and inhospitable Hindustan while they yearned for the bracing cold of Kabul and its sweet, consoling melons. While the camp remained by the river for fifty days, Akbar went with Abu’l Fazl to visit the shrine of the Gorkhatris, near Peshawar, in a cave so deep that ‘there are nowhere else in the whole world such narrow and dark hermits’ cells as at this place’. The men had to crawl in darkness through a tortuous cave system to reach the sacred prayer spot; it was such a daunting and depressing task that most of the men lost heart and turned back.

When the great army finally reached the outskirts of Kabul, the Padshah took the fight to his half-brother. An advance guard under young prince Murad, only eleven years old, led the attack as astrologers had decreed that his was the brightest star at the time. Akbar followed with a small contingent while the bulk of the army was left behind with Salim, to advance slowly.

The attacking force included some of the famous imperial elephants, Gaj Mangal, Mukut, and Lakshmi Sundar. Each animal carried on its back four small wooden turrets from which soldiers fired muskets or shot their arrows simultaneously, a moving menace of fearsome firepower. About the